

Shingles (Zoster) - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1258 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Shingles assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published when-to-get-help guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [LOCATION] Where is the rash?
2. [DURATION] When did the rash appear?
3. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the person's exact age and sex, and are they pregnant, breastfeeding, immunocompromised, a newborn contact, or experiencing eye/ear symptoms, facial weakness, confusion, weakness, or a widespread rash?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Rash or Redness - Widespread

Is the main concern a widespread rash without the typical painful, one-sided stripe of blisters?

A widespread rash without the typical shingles pattern belongs in the Rash or Redness - Widespread pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

Using the recorded demographics rather than asking the caller to choose: is the patient age 17 or younger? Also route urgently if pregnant, breastfeeding with the rash on the breasts, the rash is on the eye or nose, there are vision changes, or the patient has a severely weakened immune system.

NHS.UK shingles guidance recommends urgent clinical review for these groups. In a generated Child variant, age 17 or younger is already established and this branch must be treated as true without asking the caller to validate age eligibility. Exact Qatar destination requires local approval.

1. Disposition level 15

Is the caller 18 or older with none of the features above, within 3 days of the rash appearing?

NHS.UK guidance: see a pharmacist within 3 days - they can provide the same antiviral medicines as a primary-care clinician.

Advice

Urgent Qatar shingles assessment

- For every generated Child variant, route directly to prompt same-day in-person assessment based on the recorded age; do not ask the caller to decide whether the age rule applies. Also arrange urgent assessment for eye/nose/ear involvement, vision or hearing change, facial weakness, severe headache/confusion, pregnancy, breastfeeding breast lesions, immunocompromise, or disseminated rash. Antiviral selection, dose, timing, pregnancy/breastfeeding use, renal adjustment, and pediatric use require the approved Qatar prescriber pathway. Call 999 for reduced consciousness, seizure, severe breathing difficulty, collapse, or rapidly severe illness. Exact Qatar destination requires local approval.
- Call Back If: eye pain, red eye, or vision change; ear rash, hearing change, or facial weakness; confusion, severe headache, weakness, or widespread rash; fever or rapid deterioration.

Governed supportive care while awaiting shingles review

- Keep the rash clean and dry, use loose clothing and a cool clean compress, and avoid adhesive dressings. Keep lesions covered where practical, wash hands, and avoid direct contact with pregnant people who have never had chickenpox, immunocompromised people, and newborn babies until lesions have crusted. Pain medicine and antiviral access require age, pregnancy/breastfeeding, allergy, kidney/liver disease, and current-medicine checks under the approved Qatar pathway.
- Call Back If: rash approaches the eye, nose, or ear; vision, hearing, facial movement, or neurological change; rash becomes widespread or patient becomes unwell.

First aid

References

- NHS.UK, "Shingles", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/shingles/> (page last reviewed 23 November 2023)

Provenance

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